“Tell Me About a Good Day”: A Conversation to Have With Your Wife Before the New Caregivers Start

A short, unhurried talk about her routines and what she wants the new team to know, written down in her words.

You know your wife better than anyone does. You could fill in most of this page without her, and that's the reason to ask: the page is going to people who have never met her, and it should sound like her.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: get her answers onto paper in her own words. It isn't for deciding anything about her care.

Who should be there

The two of you. That's enough. If someone else knows a part of her day better than you do, such as a daughter who is there in the evenings, they can join for that part or send you a note beforehand.

Pick a time when she's rested and nothing else is waiting: after her tea, not during the news.

How to open

Start with why you're asking, then ask. The Conversation Project's workbook suggests taking it in small pieces, letting the person skip any question, and taking a break if they get tired. [1]

- “Some new people are going to be helping you from this week. I'd like them to know you the way I do. Can I ask you a few things and write down what you say?”
- “I think I know most of your answers. I'd still like to hear them from you.”
- Say what the conversation is for: a short page that introduces her. Say what it isn't for: deciding anything about her care.

Questions to ask

Ask your wife

1. Tell me about a good day. What happens in it?

2. Which parts of your morning and your evening would you most want kept the way they are?

3. What would you like the new people to call you?

4. When you're somewhere new, or with people you don't know yet, what helps?

5. What do you want them to know about you? Is there anything you'd rather I left off the page?

6. Here's what I wrote down. What did I get wrong?

Ask yourself, afterwards

1. Which lines on the page are her words, and which are mine?

2. Where did her answer differ from the one I would have given for her?

How to write down what was said

Put her words in quotation marks and your own additions without them. Where her answer and yours differ, write both and don't settle it.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHOSE WORDS	READ BACK TO HER?	WHERE MY ACCOUNT DIFFERS
“Tea first, before anybody talks to me.”	Hers	Yes	
“I like my main meal at midday.”	Hers	Yes	I'd have said she eats her main meal in the evening
Likes the bedroom door left open a little at night.	Mine	Not yet	

What not to decide yet

Leave these open on the page. “Not answered yet” is a finished line, and the questions about diet and care belong to her clinicians and the new team.

- Whose version is right, where hers and yours differ.
- What she would want in the places she didn't answer.
- Whether something she likes or dislikes should be treated as a rule.

- Anything about her diet, her medications or her care.

What you can decide today

- Who will write the notes up into a short page.
- When you'll read that page back to her.
- Who will ask the new team where the page should go.
- When the two of you will look at it again, since what she wants can change.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't settle a difference between her account and yours, decide anything about her care, or tell you what the new team will do with what you bring. It gets her answers onto paper, in her words, with the differences left on the page.

Ready for the next step?

You've asked her what matters most right now and written down her answers in her words. The care interview takes that conversation further: it asks about her preferences across every part of the day, notes where the family's account and her own may differ, and turns it all into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement) and Ariadne Labs, What Matters to Me: A Workbook for Better Health Care